

THE SIEGE OF VINDANA: INVESTMENT

The King's Crusade — Module Six

OVERVIEW

The coalition arrives at Vindana and begins the work of a siege: surrounding the city, cutting its supply, and preparing the engines that will eventually break its walls. This module is the campaign's largest set piece so far and the first of two covering Vindana — this one ends in a real setback, not a victory, so that Module Seven can be the siege's actual turning point. Core scenes run four to four and a half hours; Optional Content fills out the rest of a five-hour session and can be cut if the table is short on time.

A CITY, NOT A DUNGEON

Play Vindana as a place with its own life going on behind its walls, not a monster to be whittled down. Its defenders are professional soldiers doing an ugly job competently, per the occupation's established character — nobody here is a fanatic, and Marshal Ossian Drell, who commands the garrison, is exactly as dangerous as a good officer with a strong position should be. Vale does not appear in this module, continuing the pattern from Landfall: his war is run by people like Drell, and that facelessness is still doing its work this many modules in.

Scene	Target time	Notes
1. The Lines Close	30–40 min	First sight of Vindana up close; the siege lines form.
2. Raising the Engines	45–60 min	A practical, largely non-combat scene. See Tiered Skill DCs.
3. The Cavalry Screen	45–60 min	A horse-raid on Vindana's supply. DC table and stat blocks below.
4. First Assault	60–90 min	A probing attack that does not take the city. The module's setback.
Optional Content	30–45 min	Run if the table has time; cut cleanly if not.

WHAT IS ACTUALLY HAPPENING (DM ONLY)

Vindana is well-garrisoned, well-supplied for the moment, and commanded by an officer who has had three years to prepare for exactly this. Marshal Drell knows the coalition cannot simply walk over his walls, and he is right — that is the entire point of Module Seven existing as its own module. Nothing that goes wrong for the party in Scene 4 is a trap or a trick; it is simply what a strong, competently held position does to an attacker who has not yet found its weakness. That weakness is Module Seven's job to find, not this one's.

DM Only: resist ending this module on a clean coalition victory. The whole shape of the siege depends on Investment costing something real, so that the Breaking (Module Seven) has genuine stakes to turn around. A DM running these back to back should let the table feel the setback in Scene 4 before moving on — do not soften it in the moment to keep spirits up.

SCENE 1: THE LINES CLOSE

Vindana up close is larger and better defended than it looked from the ridge in Module Five — walls thick enough to have shrugged off worse than a first coalition army, a harbour still working under the garrison's control, watch-fires along every tower by the time the coalition's own lines are staked out around it. Twenty-eight thousand people lived here before the fall. Perhaps nineteen thousand do now.

Two things about those walls are worth putting in front of the party on the first day, because both of them pay off later. The inner wall is Standing Light stone, and for six centuries this city glowed faintly from its own defences on any clear night — the outer face of the thing the coalition has come to break was, until fourteen months ago, the most beautiful curtain wall in the world, and it is dark. And the harbour behind it is not a harbour any more so much as a spout: everything that leaves Elduvaine leaves through Vindana, weighed, docketed, and carried in Norvatch bottoms under a standing contract. A coalition that closes this port is not only taking a city. It is putting a cork in the only hole the kingdom is draining out of, and Marshal Drell knows the arithmetic of that considerably better than the officers besieging him do.

By the second day, Vindana is ringed rather than merely approached — coalition tents in a wide arc from harbour-mouth to inland hill, cook-fires enough to be seen from the walls, and somewhere above the gatehouse, a banner the party does not recognise, raised deliberately high enough to be read from the coalition's own lines. Marshal Drell wants them to know exactly who they are besieging.

Let the party see the siege take shape as a logistics problem as much as a military one: where the coalition's three contingents camp relative to each other, how supply lines from Caerwyn are organised, and — if Module Four was played — whether Doria Kell or her Norvatch contacts have already found a way to profit from a besieging army's needs.

SCENE 2: RAISING THE ENGINES

The engines are Auberitz work and the crews raising them are Auberitz too — gnome engineers who designed the things and halfling quartermasters who move them, all of whom have strong views about how a siege ought to be conducted and none of whom have been asked. The party will get further here by taking the engineers seriously than by outranking them: the chief of the works is a gnome who has built eleven of these, has never once seen one used the way she intended, and will tell the party exactly what will go wrong an hour before it does.

A siege needs engines, and building them under threat of sortie is its own kind of work. This scene is largely non-

combat by design — a chance for characters who do not want to spend the whole module fighting to matter directly.

Timber comes in faster than the engineers can shape it and slower than the marshals want it. A trebuchet frame goes up crooked twice before a Harrowmark carpenter, cursing fluently in two languages, gets the joint to hold. Nobody has slept properly in three days, and everybody has an opinion about the range on the mangonels.

Use the Tiered Skill DCs below to resolve however the party wants to help — hauling material, correcting an engineer’s error, defending a work party from a probing sortie. Success speeds construction and gives Scene 4 a stronger opening position (advantage on the first round, or a wall section already weakened); failure does not lose the siege, only costs time the table can feel.

SCENE 3: THE CAVALRY SCREEN

Xavier’s own cavalry — mounted scouts and raiders, Harrowmark-trained — range beyond the siege lines to cut Vindana’s remaining supply routes inland. The party can ride with them for a fast, mobile scene very different in texture from the siege lines’ grinding patience.

The riders move like people who trust their horses more than their orders, which is not disrespect so much as long habit — Harrowmark cavalry has always worked this way, fast and loose and hard to pin down. Their captain, without much ceremony, waves the party into formation as though they had always ridden with the unit.

RUNNING THE SCENE

A supply column bound for Vindana — modest, lightly guarded, moving fast to avoid exactly this — can be intercepted on the road. This is a fast, mobile engagement; let mounted combat, terrain, and speed matter more than raw numbers. Use four Legionaries of the Sixth (Bestiary, CR 1/2) for the column’s escort: they are professionals, they will not be surprised twice, and they are still four people against a cavalry raid. The point of this scene is momentum and competence rather than danger — but let the Formation trait bite once, so the table learns before Module Seven that the Sixth fights as a unit and not as a crowd.

A successful raid here (the column stopped, captured, or turned back) meaningfully weakens Vindana’s position for Scene 4’s assault — a DM may grant advantage on one relevant roll during the assault, or simply narrate the garrison as visibly shorter on options. This is the module’s clearest chance for the party to feel unambiguously effective before Scene 4’s setback.

TIERED SKILL DCs

Easy 10, Moderate 13, Hard 16, matching the tiers used throughout this campaign.

Task	Skill	DC	Tier
Correct a flawed siege engine joint before it fails	Investigation / a relevant craft	13	Moderate
Haul and position engine timber efficiently	Athletics	10	Easy

Task	Skill	DC	Tier
Defend an engine work party from a probing sortie	Combat or relevant skill, DM’s judgement	13	Moderate
Track and intercept the supply column before it reaches Vindana	Survival	13	Moderate
Read Marshal Drell’s dispositions during First Assault	Investigation / Perception	16	Hard

SCENE 4: FIRST ASSAULT

With the engines raised and the supply raid’s results in hand, the coalition tries the walls once, before the real siege settles into its longer rhythm — not out of impatience, but to test what Drell’s defence actually looks like under pressure. This is meant to fail, or to succeed only at real cost, and the module should let that land honestly.

The first breach in the outer wall holds for less than a minute before Vindana’s garrison closes on it from three directions at once, and the coalition’s own advance stalls in the gap rather than through it. Somewhere to the left, a company that went in confident comes back considerably smaller than it went.

RUNNING THE SCENE

This can be run as a large-scale combat with the party at its centre (use Marshal Drell — see Stat Block — with six Legionaries of the Sixth and an Optio at the point of heaviest fighting, which is what a breach on a defended wall actually contains) or narrated at the level of the assault as a whole, with the party’s actions determining how badly it goes rather than whether it succeeds. Either way, the assault does not take Vindana. A clean tactical win for the party in their own local fight is entirely possible and should not contradict the larger setback — they can win their corner of a battle the coalition as a whole does not win, which is itself worth letting them feel.

STAT BLOCK

Marshal Ossian Drell

Medium humanoid (hobgoblin), lawful neutral — SRD Veteran, renamed

Armor Class: 17 (splint armor)

Hit Points: 58 (9d8 + 18)

Speed: 30 ft.

STR	DEX	CON	INT	WIS	CHA
16 (+3)	13 (+1)	14 (+2)	10 (+0)	11 (+0)	10 (+0)

Skills: Athletics +5, Perception +2

Senses: passive Perception 12

Languages: Common

Challenge: 3 (700 XP)

ACTIONS

Multiattack. Drell makes two longsword attacks. If he has a shortsword drawn, he can also make a shortsword attack.

Longsword. Melee Weapon Attack: +5 to hit, reach 5 ft., one target. Hit: 7 (1d8 + 3) slashing damage, or 8 (1d10 + 3) slashing damage if used with two hands.

Shortsword. Melee Weapon Attack: +5 to hit, reach 5 ft., one target. Hit: 6 (1d6 + 3) piercing damage.

Heavy Crossbow. Ranged Weapon Attack: +3 to hit, range 100/400 ft., one target. Hit: 6 (1d10 + 1) piercing damage.

Drell does not die or fall back easily in this module — he is meant to survive Scene 4 regardless of how the fight at the point of contact goes, withdrawing his forces in good order once the breach fails rather than pressing an advantage he does not need. Save a real, decisive confrontation with him for Module Seven if the table wants one.

Scaling First Assault. Drell (700 XP), six legionaries (600) and an optio (450) is 1,750 XP across eight monsters, $\times 2.5$ for 4,375 adjusted, or $\times 2$ for 3,500 with a party of six. Most tables are at 6th level by now: that reads Hard for four characters, Medium for five and Easy–Medium for six. This is the module's setback, so do not soften it for four; for six, add the second optio rather than more legionaries, which keeps the count out of the next band.

PUZZLES AND SET PIECES

Raising the Engines is how that scene is run. The undercity is additive and substantial — sixty to ninety minutes, and a table that wants a proper dungeon crawl can take considerably longer. It is the best thing in the module and it is optional, which is deliberate: it pays out in Module Seven for the parties that go looking.

THE UNDERCITY, KEYED

A drain and cistern system older than the walls above it, which the coalition would very much like to use and which the garrison stopped patrolling two years ago. It is the single best reward available to a party that solves this module sideways, and it pays out directly in Module Seven.

Area	What is there	Notes
A. The seaward outfall	Entry. Six feet of water at high tide, none at low.	Timing is the whole approach. Tide tables are buyable in any harbour tavern.
B. The signposted run	300 ft. of trapped corridor, every trap marked in Draconic.	Same principle as the Old Workings. The marks are honest.
C. The cistern hall	A vaulted chamber, forty feet across, waist deep.	Sound carries perfectly. Anything said here is heard at D.
D. The warren	Sixty kobolds. Larders, nests, two generations of improvement.	Run four to eight in any fight. The negotiation is the real scene.

Area	What is there	Notes
E. The old sluice	A gate mechanism, seized, that once drained the cistern.	Freeing it is DC 16 Strength or an hour with tools. It matters in Module Seven.
F. The under-wall	Where the drain passes beneath the inner wall.	This is the prize. A route under the walls, into the garrison quarter.
G. The grain undercroft	The garrison's reserve store, reachable only from F.	What the kobolds want. They cannot reach it and the party can.

THE PUZZLE: WHAT THE KOBOLDS WANT

They have had two years and nothing else to do, and they have prepared a speech. The negotiation is a three-part problem and every part has a real solution.

- **They want the grain undercroft (G).** They cannot get into it, because the only route runs under the wall past a garrison post. The party can. This is a straight trade and it is the easy part.
- **They want a written promise that nobody comes back down.** In writing, signed, by somebody with a name. This is harder than it sounds, because the party cannot bind the coalition and the kobolds know what a worthless signature looks like. A Norvatch factor can draft one that will actually hold, which is a genuinely good reason to have kept Doria Kell's goodwill.
- **They will not hand over the route until both are done.** No amount of Persuasion moves this. They have been lied to before, by the garrison, in year one, and they will tell the party about it at length.

DM Only: do not require this. Do reward it enormously. A party that has the under-wall route does not need the postern gate in Module Seven and can open the assault from inside the walls, which changes that module's opening from a wall problem into a street fight and saves a great many coalition lives the DM should mention afterward. A party that simply kills sixty kobolds gets the route as well, and gets it four hours later, and gets no help with the sluice at E, which they will want.

SET PIECE: RAISING THE ENGINES

Nine months of work at Krenholt, four hundred miles of road, and one afternoon of getting them up onto the platform in range of a wall whose garrison would very much prefer they were not. Auberitz has done this before. Auberitz is still going to lose an engine.

"The chief of the works is four feet tall, has built eleven of these, has never once seen one used the way she intended, and is currently standing on a barrel telling a Harrowmark knight exactly what will happen if he moves his horses across the traverse. He moves his horses across the traverse. Ninety seconds later a stone comes off the Ward Gate and takes the traverse, the horses, and an argument nobody is going to finish."

Three problems, running simultaneously. The platform is short of fascines and the nearest brushwood is inside

bowshot. The counterweight for the second engine is still two miles back on a wagon with a broken axle. And the garrison's own engines have the range and are ranging in, three stones at a time, adjusting.

What the party can do. Any of it. Fetch the counterweight, screen the fascine parties, or — the answer the engineers are hoping somebody thinks of — go and do something about the garrison's ranging shots, which are being directed by an observer on the Ward Gate who can be reached, with difficulty, from the seaward side.

The chief of the works will tell the party exactly what will go wrong an hour before it does, and will be right, and will not say so afterward. She is the module's best NPC and she has eleven lines in her, all of them dry.

NPC PROFILES

MARSHAL OSSIAN DRELL

A hobgoblin of perhaps fifty, and a legionary officer of the kind his people produce reliably and other peoples mostly envy: literate, unhurried, personally brave in a way he considers unremarkable, and entirely without any stake in Vale's war beyond the contract that pays for it. He has held Vindana for three years, competently, and has filed a monthly report about it every one of those months.

Vindana's garrison commander, professional rather than cruel, visibly proud of a defence he has had three years to prepare. Speech: economical, respectful of competence in an enemy, entirely without the theatrical menace a table might expect — he is fighting a siege, not delivering a villain's speech.

Open thread: Drell is this campaign's model of the occupation's real competence, and a DM can use him again in Module Seven as the officer whose actual weakness the party finds — or, if the table prefers, as an officer who can be talked into surrender once that weakness is found, rather than one who must be killed.

OPTIONAL CONTENT

THE COALITION'S OWN ARGUMENT

If the table wants more camp texture, let Oksitan and Auberitz officers disagree openly, for the first time, about how the siege should be run — patience versus a faster assault, roughly the tension the module itself just dramatised in Scene 4. No mechanical stakes; this is a chance to deepen the coalition's internal friction established in Module Four.

SOMEBODY INSIDE IS STILL FILING

A defector, a captured docket, or Ninian herself can tell the party that a magistrate of the Braid is inside Vindana and has been for three years — not in a cell, in what she insists on calling her chambers, producing correctly formatted objections at a rate the administration has never managed to stop. Ottoline Vahn is the Ward's great-aunt, she is somewhere behind the wall the coalition is about to break, and she is a hundred and sixty years into being a magistrate and quite immovable about it.

DM Only: this costs nothing and buys a great deal. It gives the siege a person inside it, it gives Module Eight's rescue somebody the party has been thinking about for two modules rather than a name off a list, and it gives the party a reason to care whether the assault in Scene Four goes into the wrong quarter. Do not let them reach her here. Do let them worry.

NINIAN'S READ ON THE CITY

If Ninian was freed at Sennoch Hall, she has real, specific knowledge of Vindana from before the occupation — a postern gate, a garrison habit, something small but true. This does not need to change the module's outcome; it is a chance to let her earlier promise (see her NPC profile) pay off in a small way.

WHAT THE DARK WALL GREW

Where the undercity's drain passes beneath the inner wall — area F on the keyed map — the Standing Light stone was drained past what it could survive, and some of it got up. Use the Light-Hollow from the Bestiary: a figure of dull, cold masonry that puts out every nonmagical light within thirty feet at the start of its turn and, once the party has only spells left, pulls those down as well.

Fight it in the dark. That is the entire design: torches go on the first round, magic on the third or fourth, and the encounter becomes a problem about position and memory rather than damage. A party carrying the standing-stone lamp from Caerwyn's baker will find it works — once — because it holds daylight rather than making it. That is worth every copper they did not pay for it.

DM Only: a single Light-Hollow is 1,100 XP, which reads below Easy on paper for any party at 6th level, and is not. The darkness is the difficulty. If the table found the undercity too gentle, put it here; if the kobold negotiation already took the evening, leave it out, and let the kobolds mention that nobody goes past the wall any more and decline to say why.

DIVERGING PATHS (DM ONLY)

- **How the engines were raised.** Smoothly or roughly — track it, and carry forward any advantage or complication into Module Seven's assault.
- **The supply raid's outcome.** A clean success meaningfully weakens Vindana for Module Seven; a failed or messy raid leaves Drell's position stronger than it might otherwise have been.
- **How First Assault was fought.** Track whether the party's own corner of the fight was a clear local win, a costly draw, or a real loss — this sets the emotional temperature Module Seven opens on.

LOOT

- **Norvatch manifests.** Found with the intercepted column — bills of lading, correctly filed, showing that a share of what feeds Vindana comes up through Norvatch bottoms under a standing contract the coalition has no legal

instrument to void. Nobody in the column did anything illegal. That is the part that will irritate the party most.

- **Captured supply.** Whatever the cavalry took from the intercepted column — modest, practical, and a genuine (if small) blow to Vindana's stores rather than treasure.
- **A garrison officer's dispatch.** Recovered from the supply column or from First Assault's dead — real intelligence about Vindana's internal state, useful DM ammunition for Module Seven rather than something that needs to pay off here.

THE REFRAIN

*By thought, and by word, and by deed,
the king's own chosen kept their creed.
Far from home, where the quiet land lay,
they held the line, and would not stray.*